



The Psalms

The School of Prayer — Meditations on the Most Beloved
Psalms

Let every thing that hath breath praise the LORD.

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Introduction

Have you ever stood before God with your heart full of words, but your tongue could find no phrases? You want to give thanks but do not know how to begin, or you suffer and do not know what to pray, or you rejoice but cannot express it, or you sin and blush with shame and dare not lift your eyes. For precisely these moments God gave us the Book of Psalms: one hundred and fifty prayers inspired by the Holy Spirit through people exactly like us, with our joys and sorrows and weaknesses, so that these prayers became the official prayer book of the Bible — the treasure with which the Church has prayed for nearly three thousand years, still fresh every morning as though written yesterday.

David the shepherd who became king prayed the Psalms, and Moses the man of God prayed them in the wilderness, and Asaph the chief of the singers, and the sons of Korah, and Solomon the wise. Then our Lord Jesus Christ Himself prayed them: on the Cross He cried out the words of the twenty-second Psalm, and into the Father's hands He committed His spirit with the words of the thirty-first Psalm. The apostles after Him, the martyrs in their prisons, the monks in their deserts, simple mothers in their homes — generation after generation found in the Psalms a tongue for their hearts. And today our Coptic Church still prays the Psalms every day: in the Agpeya prayers throughout the hours, in the Liturgy where the Psalm is read before the Gospel, and in the Tasbeha that closes with psalms of jubilation.

The Psalms are truly the school of prayer. They do not teach us to pray with memorized words repeated by our lips while our hearts are far away; they teach us to pray with our whole being: to rejoice before God without shame, to weep before Him without a mask, to confess our sins without excuses, to thank Him for His gifts without forgetting, and to ask Him in our distress without despair. There is no honest human feeling without a psalm to embrace it and lift it to the throne of grace: fear has its psalm, sorrow has its psalm, repentance has its psalm, and thanksgiving has its psalms. Whoever learns the Psalms learns to be honest with God as he is, not as he thinks he ought to be.

In this book we have chosen for you the psalms most beloved to believers' hearts through the ages: the psalms of the Good Shepherd, the psalm of

repentance, the psalm of divine protection, and the psalms of joy, thanksgiving, unity, and praise. With each psalm you will find a simple meditation explaining its meaning in language close to your daily life, then a practical way to pray it yourself. My advice to you: do not read this book like any other book; read it kneeling if you can. Pause at each psalm, read it slowly, and make it your personal prayer. And when you finish the book, you will discover that the Psalms are no longer words on paper, but have become the language of your heart with which you address God in every circumstance of your life.

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Chapter One: What Is the Book of Psalms?

The Book of Psalms is the longest book of the Bible and the dearest to the hearts of those who pray. It is a collection of one hundred and fifty spiritual poems composed over long centuries, from the days of Moses in the wilderness to after the exile. Most are by David the prophet and king, who wrote about seventy-three psalms, which is why the whole book is nicknamed after him — the Psalms of David. But there were other authors too: Asaph, the chief of the singers in the temple; the sons of Korah of the tribe of Levi; Moses the man of God, who wrote the ninetieth psalm; Solomon the king; and others. The compilers of the book arranged these psalms into five small books, each closing with the word Amen or Hallelujah — five movements in one symphony, all ending in praise.

The word psalm in the original Hebrew means a song played on a stringed instrument, for the psalms were sung in the temple accompanied by harps, timbrels, and trumpets, with the whole people joining in. They were not merely songs for special occasions, but the daily prayers of the people: the farmer prayed them in his field, the traveler on his way, the sick man on his bed, the king on his throne. And when Christ the Lord came, He did not abolish the Psalms but fulfilled and deepened them; in the Gospel of Luke He tells His disciples after the Resurrection that He came to fulfill all that was written of Him in the Law of Moses, the Prophets, and the Psalms — that is, the Psalms themselves were speaking of Him and awaiting Him. And so the early Church read the Psalms with new eyes: it found in them prophecies of Christ's sufferings, His resurrection, and His eternal kingdom, and prayed them in its gatherings from its very first day.

The most beautiful thing about the Psalms is that they are the complete school of prayer. Many think prayer is only asking for needs, so they pray when they need and fall silent when they are satisfied. But the Psalms teach us that prayer is a living relationship with the living God, with every shade of speech: praise that glorifies God for who He is, thanksgiving that remembers His

kindness, confession that exposes sin, petition that presents need, honest lament that pours out pain, and even crying out in the darkness when God seems far away. And amazingly, God did not delete from His holy book the prayers of anger, bewilderment, and complaint; He kept them so we would learn to come to Him with our true hearts, not with masks of piety. The one who cries from the depths in Psalm 130 is the same one who shouts for joy in Psalm 100; the one who weeps over his sin in Psalm 51 is the same one who dances in praise in Psalm 150. This is how the Psalms teach us to pray as complete human beings, not as counterfeit angels.

The Psalms are bound to the life of the Coptic Church with a bond that cannot be broken. The seven Agpeya prayers throughout the day are built chiefly on the Psalms: we pray them at Prime and at the Third, Sixth, and Ninth hours, at Vespers, Compline, and the Midnight Praise — so that the believer who prays the Agpeya prays the Psalms every day without realizing it. In the Divine Liturgy a passage from the Psalms is read immediately before the Gospel, as though the Church wants to prepare our hearts with David's words before we hear Christ's words. In the daily Tasbeha and the Midnight Praise we chant the Psalms, closing with the Fourth Hoos — Psalms 148, 149, and 150. Many of the Church's hymns and praises are taken from verses of the Psalms literally. The Psalms are not an old book on a shelf; they are the very air that Coptic prayer breathes.

When you read the Psalms you will discover a wondrous secret: that words written thousands of years ago describe precisely what you feel today. The fearful finds his fear written in Psalm 91, the sorrowful finds his tears in Psalm 42, the repentant finds his confession in Psalm 51, the thankful finds his shout of joy in Psalm 100. This is the work of the Holy Spirit who inspired them: He made them a mirror for every human heart in every age. So do not read the Psalms as a student hunting for information, but as one who prays, searching for God. Read the psalm slowly, pause at the verse that touches your heart, repeat it, make it your own prayer, and speak with God in its words and then in your own. And with time you will discover that the Psalms are no longer a book you read, but a friend who accompanies you, a teacher who guides you, and a ladder you climb each day one step closer to the heart of God.

Chapter Two: Psalm 1 — The Way of the Righteous

The Book of Psalms opens with Psalm 1 like a golden gate through which we enter the world of prayer. It is a short psalm, yet it sets before us life's most important decision: which road will you take? All of life — as the psalm sees it — is two roads and no third: the way of the righteous and the way of the ungodly, and every person walks in one of them whether he wills it or not. The psalm begins with the beautiful word Blessed — O the happiness and bliss of — saying: Blessed is the man that walketh not in the counsel of the ungodly, nor standeth in the way of sinners, nor sitteth in the seat of the scornful. Notice the precise progression: he walks, then stands, then sits. Evil begins with a passing step in bad company, turns into a lingering stand and habit, and ends seated and settled in the gathering of mockers. Truly happy is the one who refuses the first step from the start, keeping his heart pure before it is stained.

Then the psalm paints the positive portrait of the happy man: But his delight is in the law of the LORD; and in his law doth he meditate day and night. True happiness is not only in turning away from evil, but in clinging to the good; not in emptiness but in fullness. The law here means the whole word of God, and meditate means the quiet, deep repetition, as though chewing food to draw out all its nourishment. The blessed man is the one who makes God's word his daily delight: he reads it in the morning and his day is illumined by it, ponders it in the evening and his night is calmed by it, repeats it in his heart day and night until it becomes part of his thinking and his decisions. This is the secret of spiritual strength: not in shifting feelings, but in the steadfast Word dwelling in the heart.

Then comes the psalm's loveliest image: And he shall be like a tree planted by the rivers of water, that bringeth forth his fruit in his season; his leaf also shall not wither; and whatsoever he doeth shall prosper. What a picture! A tree planted by water does not fear drought, because its roots reach a constant source; it bears fruit in its season, neither early nor late; its leaf is always

green, a witness to its vitality; and all it produces is successful and blessed. So it is with the believer rooted in God's word: seasons of drought and distress may come upon him, but he does not wither, for his roots are deep in God's love; the fruit in his life may be delayed, but it will come in the season God appointed; and people around him see the greenness of his life and wonder where this peace comes from amid the storms. Steadfastness is not in circumstances, but in roots.

In contrast the psalm gives the sad picture: The ungodly are not so: but are like the chaff which the wind driveth away. Chaff is the light husk that flies with the first breath of wind — no roots, no fruit, no weight. So is the life built on the counsel of the ungodly: it looks big and dazzling from afar, but is light and hollow within, and the first real wind of trial scatters it and exposes its emptiness. Therefore the psalm says the ungodly shall not stand in the judgment, nor sinners in the congregation of the righteous. It closes with the decisive verse: For the LORD knoweth the way of the righteous: but the way of the ungodly shall perish. God is not absent from the scene; He knows your way by name, walks it with you, and keeps you to the end — while the other road ends in ruin, however prosperous it looked at the start.

How do you pray with Psalm 1? Begin your day with it and ask yourself honestly: which road am I walking today? Then keep a daily appointment with God's word, even ten minutes: read a small passage, pause at one verse, and repeat it in your heart all day. And pray like this: O Lord, make me like the tree planted by the rivers of water; stretch my roots deep into Your love, give me fruit in its season, and let my leaf not wither in days of drought. Keep me from the first step on the way of evil: from bad counsel, from the long stand with sinners, from sitting in the seat of mockers. Teach me to find my delight in Your word, not in people's words, and to meditate on it day and night. For You know my way, O Lord, and in Your hands I walk at peace, for the way of the righteous is kept in Your heart, and its end is eternal life with You. Amen.

Chapter Three: Psalm 8 — How Excellent Is Thy Name

Among life's loveliest moments are those when you stand at night under a clear sky studded with stars and feel, all at once, your own smallness and the greatness of the Creator. From such a moment Psalm 8 was born — the hymn of holy wonder. David begins with a shout repeated at the psalm's beginning and end, like a refrain he never tires of: O LORD our Lord, how excellent is thy name in all the earth! Before speaking of man or creation, he begins with God Himself and the majesty of His name filling the whole earth, from sunrise to sunset, from the depths of the seas to the mountain tops. When your eyes are filled with God's glory, all false human glories shrink before them — and so does your worry, for you discover you are in the hands of a great God for whom nothing is too hard.

Then David lifts his eyes to the heavens and says: When I consider thy heavens, the work of thy fingers, the moon and the stars, which thou hast ordained; what is man, that thou art mindful of him? and the son of man, that thou visitest him! Ponder the contrast: the vast immeasurable heavens and the uncountable stars are merely the work of God's fingers — and fingers signify His finest, gentlest works; what then of His mighty arm! Before this immense universe stands man, a tiny point unseen, and David asks the question every honest thinker has asked: what is man, that God should remember him? Does this small, weak creature deserve the attention of the Creator of the worlds? The question is not despair but wonder mingled with gratitude, for David knows the astonishing answer he will give in the next verse.

And the answer comes, lifting man from the dust to glory: For thou hast made him a little lower than the angels, and hast crowned him with glory and honour. In God's sight man is not a worthless insect nor a mistake in the universe, but the crown of creation: a little lower than the angels in rank, yet crowned with glory and honor like an enthroned king. Then he adds: Thou madest him to have dominion over the works of thy hands; thou hast put all

things under his feet: all sheep and oxen, yea, and the beasts of the field; the fowl of the air, and the fish of the sea. God did not create man as a spectator of the universe, but as its steward and keeper, a partner in His authority over creation. This dignity lays a great responsibility on us: to treat creation — including our bodies and others' bodies and the nature around us — with the respect befitting one whom God has crowned.

The Church read this psalm in the light of Christ and it grew more beautiful still; the Epistle to the Hebrews quotes it and says it was fulfilled completely in Jesus Christ, who for our sake became a little lower than the angels when He took flesh, suffered, and died, then was crowned with glory and honor in His resurrection and ascension. Psalm 8 is not merely a poem about nature, but a prophecy of the true Son of Man who restored to humanity the dignity lost by sin. When you pray it, remember that your worth is not in your bank balance, your position, or people's admiration, but in the fact that the Creator of the heavens and the earth remembers you, visits you, and crowns you with His glory. You matter to God so much that His Son died for you; never despise yourself, and never let anyone else despise you.

How do you pray with Psalm 8? Go out on a clear night and look at the sky, or stand before the wide sea, or contemplate a small flower in its astonishing detail, then begin your prayer with David's shout: O LORD our Lord, how excellent is Thy name in all the earth! Then ask with him: what is man, that You are mindful of me, O Lord? And wait for the answer in your heart: I remember you because I love you, and I have crowned you with My glory. Thank God for your dignity as a human made in His image, and apologize to Him for every time you insulted this image by sin, or by despising yourself or others. Then hand over to Him your stewardship of your life: your body, your time, your talents, your environment, and ask Him to teach you to manage them as a faithful steward. And end as you began: O LORD our Lord, how excellent is Thy name in all the earth! For a prayer that begins in wonder at God's greatness can only end in praise.

Chapter Four: Psalm 19 — The Law of the LORD Is Perfect

Psalm 19 shows us that God speaks to us in two languages: the language of creation and the language of the Word. David begins with the first, saying: The heavens declare the glory of God; and the firmament sheweth his handywork. Day unto day uttereth speech, and night unto night sheweth knowledge. The whole universe is an eloquent silent sermon: the sun rising faithfully each morning, the stars moving in their orbits with precision, the seasons following in order — all testify that behind this universe stands a wise mind and unlimited power. David affirms that this testimony is universal and needs no translation: There is no speech nor language, where their voice is not heard. Their line is gone out through all the earth, and their words to the end of the world. No person on earth can say he never heard of God, for creation itself preaches Him day and night.

Then David suddenly moves from the heavens to the Word, from the silent language to the revealed language, saying: The law of the LORD is perfect, converting the soul: the testimony of the LORD is sure, making wise the simple. Here he reveals a great secret: creation proclaims God's existence and power, but it does not tell us how to be saved or how to live; God's word, by contrast, is perfect — with no lack and no error — and it converts the soul, restoring it to life after sin had killed it. Then David lists the qualities of the Word with the joy of one who found a treasure: The statutes of the LORD are right, rejoicing the heart: the commandment of the LORD is pure, enlightening the eyes. The fear of the LORD is clean, enduring for ever: the judgments of the LORD are true and righteous altogether. The Word is not heavy chains, as some think, but the source of joy, light, and wisdom; whoever keeps it is not robbed of life but finds true life.

David reaches the height of enthusiasm when he compares God's word to the most precious things men know, saying: More to be desired are they than gold, yea, than much fine gold: sweeter also than honey and the honeycomb.

Gold stands for the highest material value, honey for the highest sensory delight, and God's word surpasses them both: it is more precious than all the world's riches and sweeter than all its pleasures. Then he adds two practical benefits: Moreover by them is thy servant warned: and in keeping of them there is great reward. The Word warns us of deadly roads before we fall into them, like warning signs on a mountain road, and whoever keeps it receives great reward — not only in heaven but in daily life: peace of conscience, wisdom in decisions, and the blessing of obedience. Blessed is he who makes the Word a lamp to his feet and a light to his path.

But honest David is not content with theoretical praise of the Word; he makes it a mirror exposing his heart, and prays: Who can understand his errors? cleanse thou me from secret faults. God's word is like a bright light revealing dust unseen in darkness; how many secret sins hide in our hearts unnoticed: hidden pride, disguised selfishness, buried bitterness! So David cries out for deep cleansing, then adds: Keep back thy servant also from presumptuous sins; let them not have dominion over me: then shall I be upright, and I shall be innocent from the great transgression. He knows the most dangerous enemies are not outside but within: pride that dominates the heart and blinds it to the truth. He closes the psalm with the loveliest prayer a reader of the Word can pray: Let the words of my mouth, and the meditation of my heart, be acceptable in thy sight, O LORD, my strength, and my redeemer. The goal of the Word is not mental knowledge, but that our words and thoughts be acceptable before God.

How do you pray with Psalm 19? Begin by contemplating creation: look from your window at the sky and say with David: the heavens declare Your glory, O Lord, and I hear and believe. Then open your Bible and read one chapter slowly, and ask yourself: what do these words say to me today? What hidden sin do they expose in my heart? Pray with David: O Lord, cleanse me from secret faults, and keep me from pride. Then make the last verse your constant daily prayer, especially before you speak, write, or post anything: let the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable in Your sight, O LORD, my strength and my redeemer. How beautiful for your mouth and your heart together to be acceptable before God! And if you want a

practical program, read one chapter of the Bible each day in this way, and after months you will discover that the Word has indeed become more desirable to you than gold and sweeter than honey.

Chapter Five: Psalm 22 — The Cry of the Cross

This is the most awesome and most glorious of the psalms together, for it is the psalm our Lord Christ prayed on the Cross. It begins with the cry that shook heaven and earth: My God, my God, why hast thou forsaken me? why art thou so far from helping me, and from the words of my roaring? In history's darkest hour, with the Lord of glory hanging between heaven and earth bearing the sins of the world, He cried these words that David wrote a thousand years before. Here is a wondrous secret worth pondering: Christ was not suffering as one who had lost His faith — He was praying! At the height of pain He clings to prayer, and in the moment of feeling forsaken He calls: My God, My God — for he who cries My God still believes He is his God, and he who asks why hast Thou forsaken me still trusts that forsakenness is not the end. So the Lord taught us that crying out in distress is not weak faith but the summit of honest prayer.

Then the psalm describes the sufferings of the Crucified in astonishing detail, fulfilled literally on the Cross centuries later: Many bulls have compassed me: strong bulls of Bashan have beset me round. They gaped upon me with their mouths, as a ravening and a roaring lion — an exact picture of the Jews and soldiers surrounding the Cross in mockery. Then He says: I am poured out like water, and all my bones are out of joint: my heart is like wax; it is melted in the midst of my bowels — a medically precise description of crucifixion's agonies: total bodily collapse, dislocated joints, a failing heart. He continues: My strength is dried up like a potsherd; and my tongue cleaveth to my jaws — the severe thirst that made the Lord say, I thirst. Then the most famous prophecy: they pierced my hands and my feet — crucifixion itself, unknown in David's time! They part my garments among them, and cast lots upon my vesture — exactly what the Roman soldiers did beneath the Cross. The psalm is not mere sad feeling, but a prophetic map the Holy Spirit drew of Christ's sufferings a thousand years before.

But the psalm does not end at the Cross; it crosses over to the resurrection and salvation, and the cry turns to praise: But be not thou far from me, O LORD: O my strength, haste thee to help me. Then He proclaims: I will declare thy name unto my brethren: in the midst of the congregation will I praise thee — which the risen Christ did when He appeared to His brethren the disciples and preached to them. The praise widens to embrace all nations: All the ends of the world shall remember and turn unto the LORD: and all the kindreds of the nations shall worship before thee. For the kingdom is the LORD's: and he is the governor among the nations. The Cross that looked like defeat became victory, and the cry that looked like despair became the key of salvation for the whole world. So the psalm teaches us that God leaves no honest cry unanswered, and that the darkest nights always precede the greatest victories.

The Church reads this psalm in the prayers of Holy Week, especially in the hours when we contemplate the Lord's sufferings, because she wants us to stand beneath the Cross not as spectators but as participants: our sins are what pierced His hands, our mockery surrounded Him like the bulls — yet His prayer for us never ceased. When you pray this psalm in Holy Week, do not read it as ancient history; stand before the Crucified and say to Him: My God, My God — I am the one who forsook You by my sins, yet You did not forsake me; the Father forsook You for my sake, so that He might never forsake me. The psalm teaches us to understand the Cross not as a painful event in the past, but as a living present that forgives our sins today and bears our pains now.

How do you pray with Psalm 22? When you pass through severe distress and feel God is far, do not be ashamed to cry out with Christ: My God, My God, why have You forsaken me? For this cry, on the Lord's lips, was sanctified and became an accepted prayer. Complain to Him of your pain in detail as David did: describe your fears, your enemies, your bodily and spiritual pains without beautifying. Then hold to faith amid the pain and say: But be not far from me, O LORD; O my strength, haste to help me. And remember that Christ suffered before you and suffers with you now, for He is the High Priest who can be touched with our infirmities, having been tempted in all things as we are. Then

cross over with the psalm from lament to praise: even before you see relief, begin thanking God, for He heard His Son's cry on the Cross and will hear your cry too. He who raised Christ from the dead is able to raise you from every tomb: the tomb of sorrow, the tomb of sickness, the tomb of despair. Amen.

Chapter 6

Chapter Six: Psalm 23 — The LORD Is My Shepherd

No psalm in the whole world is dearer to human hearts than this one. Children recite it in Sunday school, the elderly pray it on sickbeds, it is read at weddings and funerals, and believers memorize it by heart in every language. The secret lies in just two words with which David opens — David the expert shepherd who knew the meaning of shepherding from long years with his sheep in the wilderness of Bethlehem — saying: The LORD is my shepherd. He did not say the LORD is a shepherd in general, but my shepherd, mine personally; God is not a distant philosophical idea, but a shepherd who knows His sheep by name and cares for each one. From this truth flow all the psalm's blessings: I shall not want — I shall lack nothing I truly need, for the Good Shepherd knows my needs before I know them myself, and prepares for them before I ask.

Then David describes the Shepherd's daily care, saying: He maketh me to lie down in green pastures: he leadeth me beside the still waters. The green pastures are God's satisfying word on which the heart feeds and lies down at rest, not in anxiety; the still waters are the peace of the Holy Spirit quenching the inner thirst that the world's waters cannot quench. Then he says: He restoreth my soul — how lovely this phrase is for everyone who has lost the way! A sheep may stray in the mountains, but the shepherd does not leave it; he seeks it and restores it to the flock. So when you drift from God by sin or by lukewarmness, do not despair, for your Shepherd specializes in restoring straying souls. He leadeth me in the paths of righteousness for his name's sake — God leads us in the right way not because we deserve it, but for His name and glory; His reputation as the Good Shepherd is bound up with the safety of His sheep, so He will never let us go astray.

Then comes the most famous part, which has comforted millions in their darkest hours: Yea, though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil: for thou art with me. Note the precision: he did not say we

will never walk through the valley of the shadow of death — suffering and danger are part of life's journey — but that we will not fear, because the Shepherd is with us in it. And the shadow of death is not death itself, but its shadow; and a shadow cannot hurt! Sickness, danger, persecution — all are mere passing shadows while the Shepherd is present. Then he says: thy rod and thy staff they comfort me — the rod to drive off wolves and enemies, the staff to draw back the straying sheep and guide it; God's discipline and His protection together are our comfort. Do not fear the rod that disciplines you, for it is in the hand of a Shepherd who loves you, and do not worry about enemies, for the same rod protects you from them.

The psalm reaches the summit of divine generosity, saying: Thou preparest a table before me in the presence of mine enemies. While enemies surround me expecting my ruin, God prepares a feast of celebration before their very eyes! This is always His way: He does not remove the enemies around me at once, but honors me in their midst, to teach them and to teach me that the victory is His. Then he says: thou anointest my head with oil — the Eastern custom of honoring a dear guest — my cup runneth over, overflowing to those around me. God's blessing is not mere sufficiency but abundance: He gives me more than I need so that I may overflow to others. It closes with the blessed certainty: Surely goodness and mercy shall follow me all the days of my life: and I will dwell in the house of the LORD for ever. All the past was goodness and mercy following me like two faithful guards, and all the future is dwelling in the house of the LORD forever. What an ending!

How do you pray with Psalm 23? Make it your personal prayer by turning every verse into direct address: say, O Lord, You are my shepherd; I shall not want. Then list your true needs one by one and hand them to Him: my need for peace, for healing, for provision, for wisdom — You know them, O Good Shepherd. And when you pass through the valley of the shadow of death — sickness, fear, or loss — repeat aloud: I will fear no evil, for You are with me; Your rod and Your staff, they comfort me. Look at your adversaries and say: O Lord, prepare Your table before me, and do not be troubled by them. Thank Him for the oil with which He anointed your head — the anointing of the Holy Spirit — and for the overflowing cup. And memorize this psalm by heart if you

have not; it will be your companion in the hospital, on journeys, and in the long night, always reminding you that you have a Good Shepherd who laid down His life for the sheep and will never leave you until He brings you to dwell in His house forever. Amen.

Chapter Seven: Psalm 42 — As the Deer Pants

There are seasons in the spiritual life when we feel God is far, prayer is dry, and the heart is thirsty and unsatisfied. In these desert seasons comes Psalm 42 like an oasis of cool water, for it is a psalm written from a heart that knows spiritual thirst. It begins with the most famous image: As the hart panteth after the water brooks, so panteth my soul after thee, O God. The hart — the wild deer — when gripped by thirst in the wilderness runs panting, searching for water, distracted by nothing else, restless until it finds the brook, throws itself upon it, and drinks eagerly. So is the believing soul in times of dryness: neither money nor success nor amusement satisfies it; it thirsts for God Himself, for His living presence, for His face hidden from it. Then it explains: My soul thirsteth for God, for the living God: when shall I come and appear before God? The thirst is not for God's blessings but for God Himself; not for His gifts but for His face. This is the highest kind of spiritual longing.

Then the psalmist reveals his pain with touching honesty: My tears have been my meat day and night, while they continually say unto me, Where is thy God? Tears became his daily food — weeping by day where no one sees, weeping by night on his pillow — and on top of the inward pain comes outward mockery: the scoffers ask him every day, Where is your God whom you pray to? Why does He not deliver you? And this word — Where is thy God — is Satan's sharpest arrow in times of distress, for it casts doubt on the very relationship with God. But the psalmist does not flee his sweet memories; he summons them as medicine: When I remember these things, I pour out my soul in me: for I had gone with the multitude, I went with them to the house of God, with the voice of joy and praise, with a multitude that kept holyday. He remembers former days of joy when he worshiped God with the congregation in the temple — and these memories are not for regret but for hope: the God who gladdened me yesterday can gladden me today, and the spring that watered me once will never run dry.

Then comes the heart of the psalm — the verse every believer passing through spiritual depression should memorize: Why art thou cast down, O my soul? and why art thou disquieted in me? hope thou in God: for I shall yet praise him for the help of his countenance. Notice that the psalmist is talking to himself here! He does not wait for someone to preach to him; he preaches to himself: he addresses his downcast, sorrowing soul and commands it to hope. This is deep spiritual wisdom: our feelings are not our masters; we can speak to them and lead them to hope. He does not deny the pain — he admits his soul is cast down and disquieted — but he refuses to surrender to it, planting in it the seed of hope: for I shall yet praise Him. Praise is surely coming, deliverance is certain, the divine face will shine again. He repeated this verse three times in Psalms 42 and 43, as though urging us to memorize it and repeat it whenever our souls are cast down.

The psalmist continues describing the depth of the trial, saying: Deep calleth unto deep at the noise of thy waterspouts: all thy waves and thy billows are gone over me. Trials come like successive waves: a wave of sorrow followed by a wave of fear followed by a wave of doubt, until a person feels he is drowning in bottomless depths. But in the midst of drowning he clings to the last rope: Yet the LORD will command his lovingkindness in the daytime, and in the night his song shall be with me, and my prayer unto the God of my life. Even in the night — the symbol of darkness and distress — he does not stop singing and praying, for his God is the God of his whole life: by day and by night, in joy and in sorrow. Then he closes with an honest question followed by surrender: I will say unto God my rock, Why hast thou forgotten me? why go I mourning because of the oppression of the enemy? — he reproaches God as a friend reproaches a friend, not as a servant rebelling against his master. And this honest reproach is the height of trust: he who does not trust God would not reproach Him at all.

How do you pray with Psalm 42? When you feel spiritual dryness, do not pretend all is well; confess your thirst and say: my soul thirsts for You, O God, for the living God. Describe your dryness to Him in detail: my prayer is cold, Your word does not touch me, my tears have become my food. Then summon your sweet memories with God: remember a time you felt His presence

strongly, or a prayer He answered, or a joy that filled your heart in the Liturgy — and say to Him: O Lord, You are the same yesterday and today; come again and quench my thirst. Then speak to your downcast soul as the psalmist did: Why are you cast down, O my soul? Hope in God, for I shall yet praise Him! Repeat it aloud until your ears hear it and your heart believes it. And do not stop singing in the night: sing a hymn you love, even with your tears, and pray even with few words. And remember that thirst for God is a sign of life, not of death; the dead do not thirst, but you are still alive, the spring is still there, and the meeting is near. Amen.

Chapter Eight: Psalm 51 — The Psalm of Repentance

Every person has a fall he remembers with regret, and for David the king his fall was the most famous in history: adultery with Bathsheba, then arranging the murder of her husband Uriah to cover the crime. After nearly a whole year of silence and flight, God sent him Nathan the prophet, who confronted him with the famous story and then the cutting word: Thou art the man! David collapsed and confessed: I have sinned against the LORD. From this honest confession Psalm 51 was born — the greatest psalm of repentance in the Bible — which the Church prays in the Agpeya every day, especially at Prime, so the believer begins his day with it as he washes his face with water. For repentance with David is not a seasonal ritual but a daily way of life, because every day carries its faults that need the washing of mercy.

The psalm begins by appealing to God's mercy, not to man's merit: Have mercy upon me, O God, according to thy lovingkindness: according unto the multitude of thy tender mercies blot out my transgressions. David does not say, Have mercy because I am the king, or because I served You greatly, or because my sin is small — he leans on God's own character: His wide mercy and His abundant compassion. Then he asks for complete washing: Wash me thoroughly from mine iniquity, and cleanse me from my sin. Sin is not a surface stain wiped with a tissue, but a deep defilement needing thorough washing and total cleansing that only God can do. Then comes full confession with no excuses and no blaming of circumstances: For I acknowledge my transgressions: and my sin is ever before me. Against thee, thee only, have I sinned, and done this evil in thy sight. He does not say, Satan tempted me, or circumstances drove me, or she seduced me — he confesses: I sinned, my sin never leaves my sight, and I stand guilty before You alone, O God. This is true repentance: to call sin by its name, to bear its full responsibility, and to stand before God naked with no excuses.

Then David asks for something deeper than forgiveness: a new creation. He says: Create in me a clean heart, O God; and renew a right spirit within me. Notice he did not say, Repair my heart, but create — for a heart polluted by sin is not fixed by patching; it needs a new creation that God Himself makes, as He created the heavens and the earth. Then he prays the prayer at which hearts tremble: Cast me not away from thy presence; and take not thy holy spirit from me. The greatest fear of the true penitent is not punishment, but losing God's presence and having His Holy Spirit taken away. Then he asks: Restore unto me the joy of thy salvation; and uphold me with thy free spirit. Sin had stolen from him the joy of salvation — he prayed without joy and sang without taste — and he wants that joy back, not by pretense but by the Holy Spirit's work within him.

The psalm reveals a wondrous secret about God's heart, saying: For thou desirest not sacrifice; else would I give it: thou delightest not in burnt offering. The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit: a broken and a contrite heart, O God, thou wilt not despise. God does not want rituals without a heart: no animal sacrifices, no formal fasts, no prayers repeated by the lips — He wants the broken heart that confesses its weakness and the contrite spirit that truly repents. And how lovely the promise: thou wilt not despise! People may despise the repentant sinner and remind him of his past, but God never despises a broken heart returning to Him. Indeed, the sincere penitent becomes a blessing to others, for David says: Then will I teach transgressors thy ways; and sinners shall be converted unto thee. He who has tasted forgiveness becomes its witness, and he who has tasted the sweetness of repentance invites others to the same table.

How do you pray with Psalm 51? Make it your prayer whenever you feel the weight of sin, and never postpone repentance. Begin by appealing to mercy: Have mercy upon me, O God, according to Your lovingkindness; according to the multitude of Your tender mercies blot out my transgressions. Then name your sins by name before God honestly: do not say I sinned in general, but confess the specific sin troubling your conscience. Then ask for the new heart: Create in me a clean heart, O God — and believe that God can create in you what you cannot repair yourself. And pray with tears if you can: Cast me not

away from Your presence, and take not Your Holy Spirit from me. Then rise and confess before your father of confession, for the secret repentance between you and God is completed by the sacramental confession Christ instituted, and crowned by partaking of the Holy Mysteries that wash and purify. And always remember: however great your sin, God's mercy is greater; however long your estrangement, His arms are open; and a broken and contrite heart God will never despise. Start today: pray this psalm at Prime every morning, and you will discover that daily repentance is the secret of lasting joy and deep peace. Amen.

Chapter Nine: Psalm 84 — How Amiable Are Thy Tabernacles

There is a longing dwelling in every true believer's heart that the world does not know: the longing for God's house. A person may love his home, his country, his work, yet his heart still yearns for another place: the church where he meets God and his brethren, the altar where the sacrifice is offered, the atmosphere of prayer where he forgets the world's cares. From this deep longing Psalm 84 was born — one of the dearest psalms to praying hearts — which the Church made part of the Agpeya psalms we pray through the day. It begins with the heart-melting shout: How amiable are thy tabernacles, O LORD of hosts! God's house is lovely — not merely beautiful but sweet, with the taste of honey in the soul's mouth. Then it describes the intensity of longing: My soul longeth, yea, even fainteth for the courts of the LORD. The longing here is not a cold wish, but fainting — the strongest degree of yearning — until heart and flesh together cry out: my heart and my flesh crieth out for the living God. Longing for God is not a mere spiritual feeling; it shakes the whole being: the heart beats and the body trembles with longing for the meeting.

Then the psalmist gives a deeply moving image: Yea, the sparrow hath found an house, and the swallow a nest for herself, where she may lay her young, even thine altars, O LORD of hosts, my King, and my God. Even the little birds found shelter in God's temple: the weak sparrow and the migrating swallow built their nests in the temple's crevices, and there the swallow lays her young safe and secure. If birds find a home at the Lord's altars, how much more man, created in God's image! The deep meaning: God's house is open to all — small and great, near and far, the migrating bird and the wandering man — all who come find a warm nest and a faithful shelter. Then he proclaims: Blessed are they that dwell in thy house: they will be still praising thee. True happiness is not in luxurious palaces but in abiding continually in God's house, where all of life is unceasing praise.

The psalm describes the pilgrims' journey to God's house, saying: Blessed is the man whose strength is in thee; in whose heart are the ways of them. The true believer carries the map of God's house in his heart wherever he goes: at work, in travel, in exile, his heart is always turned toward the church. Then it says of these pilgrims: Who passing through the valley of Baca make it a well. The road to God's house may pass through valleys of weeping — trials, pains, losses — but the believing pilgrims turn the valley of weeping into a well of blessing! Tears shed on the road to God are not wasted; they become wells watering others. It continues: They go from strength to strength, every one of them in Zion appeareth before God. The spiritual journey is not from weakness to weakness, but from strength to strength: every step toward God increases your strength, and every day on the road brings you closer to the goal until you finally stand before God Himself.

Then the longing reaches its height in the phrase that became a proverb: For a day in thy courts is better than a thousand. The psalmist does the math precisely: one day in God's presence is better than a thousand days in the world's palaces and pleasures! Then he says: I had rather be a doorkeeper in the house of my God, than to dwell in the tents of wickedness. He prefers to be merely standing at the threshold of God's house — the lowest rank, the farthest place — than to dwell in luxury in the tents of the wicked. How far this is from the world's logic, which measures happiness by space, location, and comfort! It closes with certainty: O LORD of hosts, blessed is the man that trusteth in thee. All blessedness, happiness, and blessing are in trusting God; whoever trusts in Him finds a house that cannot be shaken and a joy that never ends.

How do you pray with Psalm 84? Before you go to church — for the Sunday Liturgy or any prayer — read this psalm at home and make it the preparation of your heart: say, How amiable are Thy tabernacles, O LORD of hosts! My soul longs for Your courts. And ask yourself: do I still long for God's house as I once did? Or has going to church become a cold habit? Ask God to renew your longing: make my heart and my flesh cry out for You, O living God. And when you pass through the valley of weeping — trial or sorrow — remember the promise: You can turn my valley of weeping into a well of blessing. In your

exile — if you are far from your church and your homeland — hold to the promise: blessed are they in whose hearts are the ways to Your house; for even if bodies are far, the heart remains dwelling in God's house. And always repeat: a day in Your courts is better than a thousand; O LORD of hosts, blessed is the man who trusts in You. Amen.

Chapter Ten: Psalm 90 — Teach Us to Number Our Days

This psalm is unique among the psalms, for it is the only one written by Moses the man of God, who lived one hundred and twenty years: forty in Pharaoh's palace, forty in the wilderness of Midian, and forty leading the people of Israel in the wilderness. From the experience of this long, eventful life Moses writes a deep meditation on the brevity of human life and the eternity of God. He begins with the great confession: LORD, thou hast been our dwelling place in all generations. Before speaking of man's perishing, he speaks of God's permanence: God was His people's refuge generation after generation — in Egypt, in the wilderness, everywhere. Then he contrasts God's eternity with man's temporality: Before the mountains were brought forth, or ever thou hadst formed the earth and the world, even from everlasting to everlasting, thou art God. God is outside time: the mountains that seem eternal were born on a certain day, but God has no beginning and no end. This truth is the foundation of all comfort: our short life is carried on the arms of the unchanging Eternal.

Then Moses describes the brevity of human life with moving images: Thou turnest man to destruction; and sayest, Return, ye children of men. For a thousand years in thy sight are but as yesterday when it is past, and as a watch in the night. Long ages in man's sight are a passing moment in the sight of the eternal God. Then he likens our life to grass: Thou carriest them away as with a flood; they are as a sleep: in the morning they are like grass which groweth up. In the morning it flourisheth, and groweth up; in the evening it is cut down, and withereth. Human life is like the grass of the field: blooming green and lovely in the morning, cut down in the evening to wither and be thrown away. This is not pessimism but wise realism: he who knows his life is short lives it with seriousness and purpose, while he who thinks it long wastes it on trifles. Then Moses confesses the cause of this perishing: For we are consumed by thine anger, and by thy wrath are we troubled. Thou hast set our

iniquities before thee, our secret sins in the light of thy countenance. Death entered the world through sin, and all we suffer of perishing and frailty comes from distance from God, the source of life.

Moses reaches the precise reckoning: The days of our years are threescore years and ten; and if by reason of strength they be fourscore years, yet is their strength labour and sorrow; for it is soon cut off, and we fly away. The average life is seventy; the strong reach eighty; and our proudest days — youth, strength, achievement — are full of labor and sorrow, then quickly cut off, and we fly away like a migrating bird. From this bitter truth Moses draws wisdom's most precious lesson: So teach us to number our days, that we may apply our hearts unto wisdom. The wise man numbers his days: knowing his balance is limited, he spends it wisely — not wasting his hours on anger, quarreling, and trifles, but investing them in what lasts forever: loving God and serving people. Numbering our days is not depression; it is the greatest motive for a meaningful life: every morning you wake is a new gift from your limited balance — how will you spend it today?

Then the psalm turns from meditation to prayer, and Moses cries: Return, O LORD, how long? and let it repent thee concerning thy servants. He asks God to return with His pleased face toward His people and to shorten the days of wrath. Then he asks for true satisfaction: O satisfy us early with thy mercy; that we may rejoice and be glad all our days. True satisfaction is not in bread but in the divine mercy that satisfies in the early morning — at the day's beginning — filling the whole day with gladness and joy. Then he asks for recompense: Make us glad according to the days wherein thou hast afflicted us, and the years wherein we have seen evil. The just God can repay years of pain with years of joy, and days of humiliation with days of honor. He closes with the lovely petition: And let the beauty of the LORD our God be upon us: and establish thou the work of our hands upon us; yea, the work of our hands establish thou it. He wants to see God's beauty reflected on his life, and God to establish the work of his hands so it is not in vain: what is built on God stands; what is built without Him collapses.

How do you pray with Psalm 90? Make it a periodic reckoning with yourself: on your birthday, at New Year, or any moment you feel the days slipping

through your fingers. Begin with the confession: O Lord, You have been my dwelling place in all my generations; from everlasting to everlasting, You are God. Then face the truth courageously: the days of my life are seventy or eighty, and their pride is labor — how many remain for me? Then pray the pivotal prayer: teach me to number my days, that I may apply my heart to wisdom. And ask yourself: if I knew I had only one year left, what would I do? Why not do it now? Then ask for the morning satisfaction: satisfy me early with Your mercy, O Lord, that I may rejoice and be glad all my days. And ask for establishing: establish, O Lord, the work of my hands; let my labor not be wasted. And close with hope: repay me for the years of pain with Your joy, and let Your beauty be upon me. Life is short, yes — but lived with the eternal God it gains eternal worth, and every day in it is counted in heaven's record. Amen.

Chapter Eleven: Psalm 91 — He Who Dwells in the Secret Place of the Most High

If there is one psalm believers have fled to in times of fear through the ages, it is Psalm 91. The traveler repeats it before his journey, the patient before his surgery, the mother over her children before they sleep, the soldier in battle. The Church made it part of the Compline prayer in the Agpeya, so we chant it every evening before closing our eyes: He that dwelleth in the secret place of the most High shall abide under the shadow of the Almighty. Sleep — when we are at our weakest and least able to protect ourselves — is the fittest time to remember we have a Guardian who never sleeps. The psalm begins with the great promise: he who dwells in the secret place of the Most High — the one settled and abiding in God's protection, not the passing visitor — shall abide under the shadow of the Almighty, dwelling safe and secure as one lodging in the shadow of a great rock that shields him from the heat of the sun and the blows of the enemy.

Then the psalm teaches us the personal language of faith: I will say of the LORD, He is my refuge and my fortress: my God; in him will I trust. Divine protection is not a general theory but a personal confession: my refuge, my fortress, my God. He who says this with a believing heart truly enters the circle of protection. Then it lists the kinds of dangers from which God delivers us: Surely he shall deliver thee from the snare of the fowler, and from the noisome pestilence. The fowler's snare stands for the hidden traps plotted by the wicked and evil spirits; the noisome pestilence for the diseases and plagues we cannot see. Then it describes the tenderness of divine protection: He shall cover thee with his feathers, and under his wings shalt thou trust. God is like the great eagle spreading its wings over its little chicks, shielding them from heat and from birds of prey; so God shields us with a fatherly tenderness beyond description. His truth shall be thy shield and buckler — God's truth and faithful promises are the shield with which we meet the arrows of doubt and fear.

Then comes the part little ones and grown-ups memorize: Thou shalt not be afraid for the terror by night; nor for the arrow that flieth by day; nor for the pestilence that walketh in darkness; nor for the destruction that wasteth at noonday. The psalm covers all times: night and day, darkness and noonday — there is no hour of the day outside God's protection. Then the astonishing promise: A thousand shall fall at thy side, and ten thousand at thy right hand; but it shall not come nigh thee. Even if thousands fall around you — in war, plague, or calamity — you are preserved, because you are in the secret place of the Most High. This is not a promise of immunity from all pain — believers get sick and die like others — but a promise that nothing touches us outside God's will, and that our life is kept in His hand until He fulfills His purpose in it. Then it says: Because thou hast made the LORD, which is my refuge, even the most High, thy habitation — the condition is clear: whoever makes the Most High his dwelling, by daily prayer and obedience, receives the promised protection.

The psalm reaches the summit of promises, saying: There shall no evil befall thee, neither shall any plague come nigh thy dwelling. For he shall give his angels charge over thee, to keep thee in all thy ways. They shall bear thee up in their hands, lest thou dash thy foot against a stone. God does not protect us by Himself alone; He charges His holy angels with our guard: they carry us in their hands as a nurse carries a child, lest he stumble on a stone in the road! Then it says: Thou shalt tread upon the lion and adder: the young lion and the dragon shalt thou trample under feet — the believer protected by God tramples the most dangerous beasts: the lion, symbol of brute force; the adder, symbol of hidden cunning; the dragon, symbol of Satan himself. Then God Himself speaks at the psalm's close, confirming the promises: Because he hath set his love upon me, therefore will I deliver him: I will set him on high, because he hath known my name. He shall call upon me, and I will answer him: I will be with him in trouble; I will deliver him, and honour him. With long life will I satisfy him, and shew him my salvation. God promises not only deliverance from trouble, but His company in it: I will be with him in trouble — and that is greater than deliverance itself!

How do you pray with Psalm 91? Make it your prayer every evening before sleep, as the Church taught us in Compline: begin with the personal confession: You, O Lord, are my refuge and my fortress; my God, in You I trust. Then list your fears one by one and hand them to Him: my fear of the night, my fear for my children, my fear of sickness, my fear of the future — cover me with Your feathers, O Lord, and shelter me under Your wings. When you hear frightening news of wars or plagues, repeat the promise: a thousand fall at my side and ten thousand at my right hand, but evil shall not come near me, for the Most High is my dwelling. And pray for your loved ones who travel and who are sick: give Your angels charge over them, O Lord, to keep them in all their ways. And before you sleep, say with confidence: You are with me in trouble, O Lord; You deliver me and honor me; with long life You satisfy me and show me Your salvation. Then sleep at peace: for He who neither slumbers nor sleeps keeps you, the angels surround your bed, and the morning will come with new mercy. Amen.

Chapter Twelve: Psalm 100 — Enter His Gates with Thanksgiving

After psalms of crying, tears, and repentance, we need a psalm to teach us joy! Psalm 100 is the hymn of pure gladness — an open invitation to all the earth to enter God's presence with shouting, singing, and praise. It begins with the universal call: Make a joyful noise unto the LORD, all ye lands! The invitation is not to a particular people or a special class, but to all the earth: small and great, rich and poor, near and far. And the joyful noise is not a shy whisper, but a loud voice of joy expressing the heart's overflow. Then it says: Serve the LORD with gladness: come before his presence with singing. True worship is not a heavy duty performed with grumbling, but a gladness with which we enter the King's presence. How many of us go to church as one going to a boring job, while the psalm invites us to enter with singing — with the singing of the heart before the singing of the lips! Joy in worship is not a luxury; it is the nature of one who knows he is entering to meet his loving Father.

Then the psalm gives the foundation of this joy, saying: Know ye that the LORD he is God: it is he that hath made us, and not we ourselves; we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture. Our joy is not hollow joy without cause, but built on firm truths: that the LORD He is God — not idols, not money, not men — and that it is He who made us: we are His creation, His workmanship fashioned with love. And not we ourselves: we are His own possession, not abandoned, not lost. His people and the sheep of His pasture: He is our Shepherd who feeds us in His green pastures. When you know who you are — God's workmanship, His possession, His people, His sheep — you cannot but rejoice! Right identity produces right joy: I am not a number in a census nor a commodity in a market, but a child of the great King and a sheep in the Good Shepherd's flock. He who knows this does not seek his worth in people's admiration or in his shifting successes.

Then the psalm teaches us the etiquette of entering God's presence: Enter into his gates with thanksgiving, and into his courts with praise: be thankful unto

him, and bless his name. As earthly kings have ceremonies for entering their palaces, so has the King of kings: we enter His gates with thanksgiving and His courts with praise. Thanksgiving is naming God's specific kindnesses: thank You, O Lord, for You healed me, for You provided for me, for You kept my children. Praise is glorifying God for who He is: You are great, You are holy, You are loving. Bless His name: confess the blessing of His name in your life. He who enters prayer grumbling and complaining is like one entering the king in filthy clothes; he who enters with thanksgiving and praise is like one entering in festive garments. So the fathers taught us always to begin our prayers with thanks before petition: thanksgiving opens heaven's gates, and grumbling closes them.

The psalm closes with the deepest reason for all this joy: For the LORD is good; his mercy is everlasting; and his truth endureth to all generations. God's goodness is not a shifting mood but a fixed nature: He is good yesterday, today, and forever. His mercy is everlasting: however long the years of our sins and weaknesses, His mercy is longer. His truth endures to all generations: the generation that trusts Him today will bequeath trust to the coming generation, for God is faithful and never fails those who trust in Him. This is the rock foundation of Christian joy: not in changing circumstances, but in the steadfast, good, merciful, faithful God. So the believer can rejoice even in distress: for his joy does not depend on what happens around him, but on who God is in Himself.

How do you pray with Psalm 100? Make it your prayer in days of joy — and even in days of sorrow, to summon joy. Begin with the shout: make a joyful noise unto the LORD, all the earth — and shout yourself, aloud if you can, or with a shouting heart if you are among people. Then come before His presence with singing: sing a hymn you love, or a church tune that gladdens your heart. Then remember your identity: I am the work of Your hands, O Lord; Yours I am, of Your people and the sheep of Your pasture — I thank You for this honor. Then enter His gates with thanksgiving: count five specific blessings you received this week and thank Him for them one by one. And His courts with praise: glorify Him for who He is, not for His gifts: You are good, You are holy, You are great. And close with certainty: for You are good, O Lord; Your mercy

is everlasting, and Your truth endures to all generations. And make it a daily habit: before asking for anything in your prayer, name three things you thank God for; daily thanksgiving is the soil in which lasting joy grows, and the thankful heart is truly the happy heart. Amen.

Chapter Thirteen: Psalm 121 — My Help Comes from the LORD

The children of Israel sang this psalm as they went up to Jerusalem for the yearly feasts, so it is called one of the Songs of Ascents. Picture the caravan: families with children and elders, walking for days on rugged mountain roads, beset by the dangers of robbers, wild beasts, and getting lost. At the journey's start the pilgrim stands, lifts his eyes to the towering mountains around Jerusalem, and asks the question every frightened traveler asks: I will lift up mine eyes unto the hills, from whence cometh my help? The mountains remind him of man's smallness and weakness before nature and its dangers. But he does not wait for the answer from the mountains themselves; he answers himself at once in faith: My help cometh from the LORD, which made heaven and earth! Help does not come from the mountains but from the Maker of the mountains; not from human strength but from the Creator of heaven and earth, for whom nothing is too hard. This is the psalm's first lesson: lift your eyes above the problem to the Maker of the heavens.

Then the psalm turns from the pilgrim's speech about himself to God's speech to him — as though the Lord Himself answers his question — saying: He will not suffer thy foot to be moved. God does not keep the road from being rugged, but He keeps your foot from slipping on it; He does not remove the stones from the path, but He steadies your steps upon them. Then He says: he that keepeth thee will not slumber. Behold, he that keepeth Israel shall neither slumber nor sleep! What a promise! Human guards slumber and sleep and grow heedless, but your divine Keeper never knows sleep: in the night, when you sleep at peace, He is awake keeping you; in the day, when you are busy with your work, He is attentive protecting you. How many dangers we escaped without knowing, because the wakeful Keeper turned them away while we slept! He who keeps Israel — His people — keeps you too, for you are of His people.

The promise continues: The LORD is thy keeper: the LORD is thy shade upon thy right hand. God is not a distant guard watching from a high tower; He is a shade clinging to you at your right hand — the hand of strength and work — shielding you from the scorching sun and every blow. Then it says: The sun shall not smite thee by day, nor the moon by night. The protection covers all times: by day, when dangers are visible, and by night, when dangers are hidden. It closes with the all-embracing promise: The LORD shall preserve thee from all evil: he shall preserve thy soul. The LORD shall preserve thy going out and thy coming in from this time forth, and even for evermore. The keeping is not from some evils but from all evil — every true evil touching your soul and your eternal destiny. He preserves your going out and your coming in: in your departures and returns, your journeys and homecomings, the beginnings and endings of your undertakings. From this time forth, and even for evermore: the protection is not temporary but eternal, covering this life and the life to come.

This psalm has been the travelers' companion through the ages, and believers still recite it before travel, pack it in their bags, and hang it in their cars. It is also the psalm of everyone starting a new, unknown road: a new marriage, a new job, emigration to a strange country, a long treatment. Every new beginning is a journey to unknown mountains, and the same question echoes: from whence comes my help? And the same answer reassures: my help comes from the LORD, who made heaven and earth. Do not fear the unknown, for your Keeper knows every road; do not dread the night, for your Keeper never sleeps; do not grieve for what you left behind, for the Keeper preserves your going out and your coming in, from this time forth and even for evermore.

How do you pray with Psalm 121? Before any journey — whether a real journey by plane or car, or a figurative journey like beginning a new stage — read this psalm and make it your prayer. Lift your eyes to the mountains of your fears and name them one by one: the mountain of sickness, the mountain of debt, the mountain of the unknown — then say: my help comes from the LORD who made heaven and earth, not from these mountains. Then receive the promises in faith: O Lord, You will not let my foot slip on this rugged road; You are my Keeper who neither slumbers nor sleeps; You are my shade upon

my right hand. And pray for your loved ones who travel and are far from you: preserve, O Lord, their going out and their coming in; keep them from all evil; preserve their souls. And sleep at peace on the night before the journey: for the Keeper is awake while you sleep, and the road is known to Him before you walk it. And when you return safely, do not forget to return to this psalm in thanks: for He who preserved your going out is He who preserved your coming in, from this time forth and even for evermore. Amen.

Chapter Fourteen: Psalm 130 — Out of the Depths I Cried

There are moments in life when we feel we are at the bottom of a dark, deep well: a heavy sorrow that will not lift, a sin too heavy to be forgiven in our eyes, or utter despair of circumstances changing. From this deep bottom rose the truest cry in the Book of Psalms: Out of the depths have I cried unto thee, O LORD! The psalmist does not pray from the mountain top but from the depths of the abyss — and yet he prays! This is the first lesson: there is no pit so deep that your voice cannot reach God from it. God is not only the God of the heights, but the God of the depths too; He hears the cry of the drowning as He hears the praise of the one standing on the shore. Then he pleads: Lord, hear my voice: let thine ears be attentive to the voice of my supplications. He does not ask for an instant answer, but for the attentive ear: that God would bend His ear to his cry as a father bends to his sick child's whisper. How we need, in our depths, this certainty: that there is a divine ear attentive to us even when the world stops its ears to us!

Then the psalmist faces the hardest question confronting every sinner in the depths: If thou, LORD, shouldest mark iniquities, O Lord, who shall stand? If God reckoned every sin with the precision of a watcher who misses nothing, who could stand before Him? The answer: no one! We are all sinners, all debtors, and sheer justice condemns all without exception. But the psalmist does not stop at justice; he crosses to mercy, saying: But there is forgiveness with thee, that thou mayest be feared! How great this truth is: forgiveness with God is not a mere possibility — it is with Him, in His treasures, ready for whoever asks. That thou mayest be feared: true fear of God — reverence and godliness — is not born of terrifying justice, but of tasted forgiveness! Man does not fear God when he only dreads His punishment, but when he tastes His forgiveness and his heart fills with awe and love. Forgiveness does not encourage carelessness, as some think; it plants the deepest kind of godliness.

Then the psalmist describes the stance of waiting — the hardest stance of faith — saying: I wait for the LORD, my soul doth wait, and in his word do I hope. The waiting here is not passive: it is the waiting of the whole soul, a hope built on God's word and promises. Then he likens his waiting to the loveliest image: My soul waiteth for the Lord more than they that watch for the morning: I say, more than they that watch for the morning! The watchmen in the long night await the morning eagerly — for morning means the end of danger and the beginning of rest — and they are certain the morning will come, however long the night. So is the believing soul in the night of trial: it waits for the Lord with a trust deeper than the watchmen's trust in the morning, for it knows the dawn of salvation will surely rise. He repeated the phrase twice for emphasis: doubled waiting needs doubled certainty. Do not despair in the night: however long the night, it has an end, and the morning is surely coming.

The psalm closes by widening from the individual to the congregation: Let Israel hope in the LORD: for with the LORD there is mercy, and with him is plenteous redemption. And he shall redeem Israel from all his iniquities. The psalmist who began with his personal cry from the depths ends by calling his whole people to the same hope: the mercy that saved him suffices to save all, and the redemption he received is plenteous, overflowing to all Israel. And He shall redeem Israel from all his iniquities — not from some of them — there is no sin greater than redemption, no black past that Christ's blood cannot wash. The Church saw in this psalm a complete picture of the work of salvation: the cry from the depths of the fall, faith in forgiveness, confident waiting for redemption, then witness to others. So this psalm is read in prayers of repentance and preparation for Communion, to remind us that the depths are not the end but the beginning of the ascent.

How do you pray with Psalm 130? When you find yourself in the depths — sorrow, sin, or despair — do not flee from prayer; flee to it: cry out from where you are: Out of the depths have I cried unto Thee, O LORD! God prefers an honest cry from the pit to a counterfeit praise from the peak. Then face your sins courageously and say: O Lord, if You should mark iniquities, who shall stand? But there is forgiveness with You, O Master! Confess your specific sins and ask forgiveness with confidence, remembering that forgiveness is with

Him, ready and waiting for you. Then enter the school of waiting: say to yourself: I wait for the LORD, my soul doth wait, and in His word do I hope. Cling to His promises as the watchman clings to waiting for the morning: the night will pass and the dawn will rise. And when your dawn of salvation rises — when the Lord forgives you and brings you out of the depths — do not keep the news to yourself; invite others as the psalmist did: let all hope in the LORD, for with Him there is mercy and with Him is plenteous redemption! Your testimony of coming out of the depths will be light for those still in them. Amen.

Chapter Fifteen: Psalm 133 — Behold, How Good and How Pleasant

In a world torn by divisions — in homes, churches, and communities — Psalm 133 comes like a fresh breeze reminding us of the loveliest thing in the Christian life: unity. It is a very short psalm — only three verses — yet among the deepest ever said about the beauty of brotherly fellowship. It begins with joyful wonder: Behold, how good and how pleasant it is for brethren to dwell together in unity! The writer stands amazed before the sight of united brethren, as one standing before a masterpiece: Behold — look! — how good — how beneficial and right — and how pleasant — how radiant and splendid! Unity among brethren is not merely a moral virtue; it is beauty itself and goodness itself. And note he said brethren to dwell together — true unity is not a passing meeting on occasions, but an abiding dwelling: a shared life, intertwined lives, hearts drawing near every day. This includes the one family, the one church, and every congregation of believers.

Then he likens unity to two of the loveliest images of the Old Testament: It is like the precious ointment upon the head, that ran down upon the beard, even Aaron's beard: that went down to the skirts of his garments. When Aaron the high priest was anointed with the holy oil, the oil was poured on his head abundantly, running down upon his beard and then to the edges of his garments, perfuming everything with a sweet fragrance. So is unity among brethren: like the precious oil poured from the head — from the spiritual leadership — running down upon all, to the very edges of the congregation, perfuming all of life with the sweet fragrance of Christ. Unity is not merely the absence of quarrel, but the positive presence of grace flowing like oil from member to member. The second image: As the dew of Hermon, and as the dew that descended upon the mountains of Zion. Mount Hermon's lofty peak was known for abundant dew watering the land around it, and this dew descending on Zion — the temple mount — symbolizes the heavenly blessing descending on the united congregation of believers, watering and refreshing it. Unity

brings the dew: the spiritual refreshing that comes not by human effort but by descent from above.

The psalm closes with the deepest reason: For there the LORD commanded the blessing, even life for evermore! Where brotherly unity is found, there the LORD commands the blessing — blessing is not chance but a divine command! And the God who commanded the blessing does not revoke His command. Even life for evermore: the fruit of unity is not mere temporary peace of mind, but eternal life beginning here. Ponder the connection: unity brings blessing, and blessing brings life. So Satan has been keen through the ages to sow division in churches and families: he knows unity opens heaven's doors and division closes them. And when Christ the Lord prayed His last prayer He said: that they may be one, even as we are one — Christian unity is not mere human agreement, but sharing in the very unity of the Trinity! Every time we unite as brethren, we reflect the image of God Himself to the world.

The words of this psalm are read in spiritual gatherings and church occasions that bring believers together, to remind them that the loveliest thing they offer God is not their programs and activities, but their unity and love. The world does not read theology books, but it reads believers' lives: when it sees loving, united brethren, it says with the psalmist: Behold, how good and how pleasant! And when it sees quarrels and divisions, it stumbles and does not draw near. So Christ the Lord said: By this shall all men know that ye are my disciples, if ye have love one to another. Love and unity are the Christian's identity card, the practical proof of the sincerity of his faith. Guard your unity with your brethren as you guard your prayer and your fasting: for God looks upon our united hearts with greater pleasure than upon our scattered fasts.

How do you pray with Psalm 133? Begin by examining your heart: is there a brother or sister in the church or the family between whom and you there is quarrel or coldness? Unity begins in the heart before it appears in the gathering. Pray for whoever wronged you: O Lord, pour Your precious oil on my relationship with my brother, and send down the dew of Your peace upon our hearts. Then take a practical step: call the one you quarreled with, visit the one you cut off, apologize to the one you wronged — for prayer for unity is not complete without practical reconciliation. And pray for your church and

your family: make us, O Lord, dwell together as true brethren, not as strangers gathered in one place. And ask for the promised blessing: there You commanded the blessing, O Lord — command it upon our home, our church, our gathering. And always remember: keeping unity is harder than building a church, and destroying it is easier than repairing it; be a builder of unity, not its destroyer, and you will see blessing descend like dew and life overflow forevermore. Amen.

Chapter Sixteen: Psalm 150 — The Closing Hallelujah

The Book of Psalms closes — indeed the whole Bible closes in its spirit — with Psalm 150, the shortest psalm and the most joyful: six verses, all unceasing shout. After one hundred and fifty psalms of crying, tears, repentance, lament, and hope, the whole book ends with one word repeated: Hallelujah! That is, Praise the LORD! This is the inevitable end of every honest journey of faith: however it began with tears, it ends in praise; however it passed through valleys of darkness, it reaches the summit of glory. So the Church made this psalm — with the two before it — the close of the daily Tasbeha, in what is called the Fourth Hoos, ending every praise with the shout: Praise the LORD! As though the Church tells us: whatever your prayers, always close them with praise.

The psalm begins by naming the place of praise: Praise ye the LORD. Praise God in his sanctuary: praise him in the firmament of his power. Praise begins in God's sanctuary — in His holy house where we gather for worship — but it does not stop at the church's walls; it stretches to the firmament of His power: the wide heavens declaring His glory. The believer praises God in church with his brethren, and praises Him also alone under the star-studded sky. Then it names the reason for praise: Praise him for his mighty acts: praise him according to his excellent greatness. We praise Him for His mighty acts — His great works in creation, salvation, and history — and we praise Him according to His excellent greatness: in the measure of His greatness in Himself, not in the measure of what we received from Him. True praise does not depend on circumstances: we praise Him in plenty and in distress, in health and in sickness, for His greatness is fixed and does not change with our changing states.

Then comes the most famous musical procession in the Bible: Praise him with the sound of the trumpet: praise him with the psaltery and harp. Praise him with the timbrel and dance: praise him with stringed instruments and organs.

Praise him upon the loud cymbals: praise him upon the high sounding cymbals! The psalm summons every musical instrument known in that age to the great praise celebration: the blaring brass trumpets, the gentle stringed psaltery and harp, the rhythmic timbrels, the wind organs, the resounding cymbals. The deep meaning: every talent, every energy, every human creativity must be used in praising God! The musician praises Him with his music, the artist with his art, the writer with his pen, the worker with his sweat, the mother with her tenderness. Nothing in life is outside the circle of praise: for every breath — every living creature that breathes — is invited to praise the LORD. Even silent nature joins: the mountains, hills, and trees all praise, in the language of the Psalms.

The psalm closes — and the whole book closes — with the verse that became the motto of Christian praise through the ages: Let every thing that hath breath praise the LORD. Praise ye the LORD! The final invitation is not to an elite of praisers nor to the temple priests, but to every breathing thing: every human breathing on earth's face, indeed every living creature! As long as breath is in you, the call to praise is upon you. This verse answers the question: why did God create us? He created us to praise Him! Praise is not a hobby for the leisured, but the very purpose of existence. He who does not praise God lives against the purpose of his creation, like a silent instrument in an orchestra playing a great symphony. So we chose this verse as this book's motto: Let everything that hath breath praise the LORD — for we want this book to be an invitation to every reader to turn the breaths of his life into unceasing praise.

How do you pray with Psalm 150? Make it the close of your prayers, as the Church made it the close of her Tasbeha: however your prayer began — with lament, petition, or confession — always close it with praise. Take your instrument of praise — your voice at least — and praise God in His sanctuary: in your church with your brethren in joy. And praise Him in the firmament of His power: in your solitude under the sky, contemplating His greatness. Count His mighty acts in your life: your salvation, your healing, His keeping of you, His uncountable gifts — and praise Him for them one by one. Then praise Him according to His excellent greatness: for Himself, not for His gifts: You are

great, O Lord; You are holy; You are worthy of all glory! And make all you possess instruments of praise: your hands clapping, your feet dancing for joy like David before the Ark, your voice shouting, your heart dancing. And remember the motto: let everything that hath breath praise the LORD — for every breath you breathe is a chance to praise, and every new day is a new praise celebration, until the day comes when we stand with the angels and saints around the throne, shouting forever and ever: Hallelujah! Amen.

Chapter Seventeen: How to Pray the Psalms Every Day

After meditating on the most beloved psalms, the most important practical question remains: how do I make the Psalms part of my daily life? A book that does not turn into prayer remains information in the head, and we want God's word in the heart. The good news is that the Church charted the road for us centuries ago: the seven Agpeya prayers — Prime and the Third, Sixth, and Ninth hours, Vespers, Compline, and the Midnight Praise — are built chiefly on the Psalms, so that one who prays the Agpeya prays dozens of psalms every day without realizing it. If you pray the Agpeya, you are already praying the Psalms; and if you do not yet, begin with one prayer a day — Prime in the morning or Compline in the evening — and you will find the Psalms flowing into your life on their own. The Agpeya is the practical school from which the saints graduated through the ages.

The second step: choose the psalm that fits your state. The Psalms are a spiritual pharmacy with a remedy for every ailment: Are you afraid? Pray Psalm 91 — He that dwelleth in the secret place of the most High — or Psalm 23 — The LORD is my shepherd. Are you sad and depressed? Pray Psalm 42 — As the hart panteth — or Psalm 130 — Out of the depths. Have you sinned and your conscience is heavy? Pray Psalm 51 — Have mercy upon me, O God. Is your heart full of thanks? Pray Psalm 100 — Enter into His gates with thanksgiving — or Psalm 150 — Hallelujah. Are you traveling or facing the unknown? Pray Psalm 121 — My help cometh from the LORD. Do you want to contemplate God's greatness? Pray Psalm 8 — How excellent is Thy name — or Psalm 19 — The heavens declare the glory of God. Do you need wisdom for an important decision? Pray Psalm 1 — Blessed is the man. Do you long for the church? Pray Psalm 84 — How amiable are Thy tabernacles. So you gain a psalm for every state, and a friend for every circumstance.

The third step: pray the psalm slowly, verse by verse. The common mistake is to read the whole psalm quickly as though performing a duty, then close the

book with nothing touching the heart. Instead, read the first verse and stop: repeat it in your heart, ponder its meaning, then turn it into personal address to God. For example, when you read, The LORD is my shepherd; I shall not want — stop and say: Yes, O Lord, You are my shepherd; I shall not want; then list your needs and hand them to Him one by one. And when you read, I will fear no evil, for Thou art with me — stop and ask: what is the evil I fear today? Then say: I do not fear it, for You are with me, O Lord. So with every verse: read, stop, ponder, address God, then move to the next. You may discover that one psalm prayed this way takes half an hour of the deepest prayer — and that is far better than reading ten psalms at lightning speed.

The fourth step: memorize one verse from each psalm. A psalm you memorize becomes your companion everywhere: in transportation, in waiting, in sleepless nights. Choose from each psalm we meditated on a verse that touches your heart and memorize it: from the first: And he shall be like a tree planted by the rivers of water. From the eighth: How excellent is Thy name in all the earth. From the twenty-third: The LORD is my shepherd; I shall not want. From the fifty-first: Create in me a clean heart, O God. From the ninetieth: So teach us to number our days. From the ninety-first: I will be with him in trouble. From the hundred and twenty-first: My help cometh from the LORD, which made heaven and earth. From the hundred and fiftieth: Let every thing that hath breath praise the LORD. And when you memorize these verses, you will find them rising from your heart spontaneously in fitting situations: when you fear, out comes, I will fear no evil, for Thou art with me; when you sorrow, out comes, Why art thou cast down, O my soul? Hope thou in God. The memorized word is the ready weapon for the day of battle.

The fifth and final step: pray the Psalms with your family. The loveliest thing you bequeath your children is not money but prayer. Sit with your family once a week — or every day if you can — read one psalm together, let each one choose a verse he likes and say why he liked it, then pray it together. And you will be amazed how children understand the Psalms with the simplicity of faith: the child who hears The LORD is my shepherd will sleep at peace, and the girl who hears her father pray Create in me a clean heart will learn repentance by example. And if you are a complete beginner, start with a

simple plan: one psalm a day for five months completes the whole book, or one psalm a week meditated on all week. What matters is to start today — not tomorrow — even with five minutes: open to Psalm 23, read it slowly, and say: O Lord, teach me to pray. And you will discover that the Psalms are not a book you read, but a river from which you drink every day and never thirst. Amen.

Conclusion

Here we have reached the end of our journey with the most beloved psalms — yet it is truly a beginning, not an end. For we have learned that the Psalms are not a book we close after reading, but a language we learn to address God with all our lives. David, who began as a little shepherd playing his harp in the wilderness, became a king playing on the harp of his heart before God in every circumstance of his life: in joy he sang, in sorrow he wept, in sin he repented, in danger he took shelter, in old age he praised. So it is with us: let the Psalms be the harp of our hearts on which we play the whole melody of our lives to God, in every season of life.

And always remember that when you pray the Psalms, you do not pray alone. With you are David and Moses and Asaph and the sons of Korah; with you is Christ the Lord Himself, who prayed these very words; with you is the Virgin Mary, whose hymn of praise was taken from the spirit of the Psalms; with you are the martyrs and saints and monks through the ages; and with you are your believing brethren today everywhere — a great cloud of witnesses praying with you in the same words! The Psalms are the common language of God's people across time and place: a simple farmer in Upper Egypt and a priest in a great cathedral, a little child and a great elder — all gather around one set of words: The LORD is my shepherd, and Let everything that hath breath praise the LORD. What a unity! What an inheritance!

Finally, this is my invitation to you: do not leave this book on the shelf. Start today — this very night — open the Book of Psalms, read one psalm slowly, and pray it from your heart. Tomorrow another psalm, and the day after another. And after months you will discover the miracle: the words of the Psalms rising from your heart spontaneously before you even open the book; in joy you will shout, Behold, how good and how pleasant!; in fear you will whisper, He that dwelleth in the secret place of the most High; in repentance you will weep, Create in me a clean heart; and at all times you will praise: Hallelujah! Then you will have learned the language of heaven, and the Psalms will truly have become the language of your heart. And the grace that began with you in the first psalm will complete with you to the last breath, until you

stand before the divine throne and join the eternal choir that never ceases to shout: Let everything that hath breath praise the LORD. Hallelujah! Amen.